SEVEN YEARS WAR



BATTLE OF QUIBERON BAY

Date	November 20, 1759
Location	Quiberon Bay, Brittany, France
Result	British victory

COMBATANTS

BRITAIN	FRANCE

COMMANDERS

Edward Hawke	Herbert de Brienne, Comte de Conflans

FORCES

Ships: 27	**Ships:** 21

LOSSES

Men: 300 **Ships:** 2	**Men:** 2,500 **Ships:** 7

THE BATTLE OF QUIBERON BAY

In 1759 France hoped to reverse the course of the Seven Years War by launching an invasion of the British Isles. An army of 20,000 men and troop transports were assembled at Quiberon Bay. The Comte de Conflans, then the commander the French fleet in Brest, was to escort the army to Scotland. The Royal Navy was maintaining a close blockade of Brest, a feat of seamanship, organization, and endurance. But in November a westerly Atlantic gale forced Admiral Edward Hawke to withdraw his blockading squadron to shelter in Torbay. Conflans seized the opportunity to sail for Quiberon Bay.

Hawke returned to Brest as soon as the weather permitted and, finding Conflans gone, pursued him southward. Delayed by erratic winds, the French were approaching the bay when the British hove into view. Conflans was not greatly outnumbered—27 ships of the line to 21—but he knew his officers and crews were far inferior. His sole advantage was possession of local pilots with an intimate knowledge of the reefs and shoals of the treacherous coast. With a gale rising from the northwest, he formed a line and sailed for the shelter of the bay. Conflans assumed Hawke would not dare to follow him in. But the British admiral signaled a "general chase" and his ships, crowding on all the sail they could bear in the howling wind, tailed the French into the narrow mouth of the bay.

THWARTED INVASION

The risk Hawke took was astonishing. Caught in a gale off a lee shore, his ships could have been shattered on the jagged rocks, leaving Britain defenseless against invasion. Instead, it was the French squadron that met disaster. The British van, commanded by Viscount Howe aboard *Magnanime*, savaged the ships of the French rear before the rest of the squadron came up to join in a mêlée made even more chaotic by the heavy seas. The captain of the French 74 *Thésée* opened his lower gun ports to bring his heaviest battery into action, only for a sudden squall to plunge the ports under water, the ship sinking instantly under full sail. Another French ship, *Superbe*, also foundered, its hull shattered by a broadside from Hawke's flagship *Royal George*. *Formidable* and *Héros*, battered into submission, struck their colors, although the raging seas prevented the British getting a prize crew aboard the latter, which was later

